

men crept in unawares" (cf. Acts 15:24f & Gal. 2:3-10).

Jude accuses those hyper-independent individualists as having "gone in the way of Cain" — rather than having stayed in the good way of the **Presbyter** Abel (ver. 11 cf. Heb. 11:2-4). He even compares them with the unruly ante diluvians — who were preached against by **Presbyters** like Enoch and Noah (ver. 14 cf. Heb. 11:2-7 & II Pet. 2:1-5f). Finally, Jude urges his addressees to heed the words previously spoken by the **apostolic Elders** (verse 17f cf. Acts 15:4f & 15:13f & 15:23f).

Owen says (XXII:37) that the pre-Mosaic independent hyper-individualists mentioned "in Jude 7... 'are set forth for an example'...of what would be God's dealing with provoking sinners at the last day." Indeed, the great Congregationalist Theologian even refers to "the Socinians" alias the hyperindividualistic anti-trinitarian Unitarians. "Many things concerning God and his essential properties" such as His **Tri-unity**, explains Owen (I:87), "they have greatly perverted. So is that fulfilled in them which was spoken by Jude."

To this, we ourselves would only add that once people depart into Independency from connectional Presbyteries reflecting the Triune God Himself as the Ultimate Trinity — it is usually not very long before those Independents further lapse into at least a 'High Arianism.' That curtails the full co-importance of the Second Person, and also especially the Third Person, within the Ultimate Presbytery of the Holy Trinity.

It also undercuts the full deity even of the First Person Himself — by leaving Him, from all eternity, as a 'non-Father' bereft of the filial companionship of a Co-eternal Son and devoid of the perpetual fellowship of the Holy Spirit. Indeed, in the very long run, Orthodox Trinitarianism and Orthodox Presbyterianism stand or fall together.

To be concluded (DV).

Correspondence..... continued from page 48.

Russell, and Wittgenstein, etc., whose works leave Van Til out of sight for sheer profundity! Also Van Til's work was built on the exegesis of others like John Murray, such that he admitted that "the lack of detailed scriptural exegesis is a lack in *all* of my writings"[!!! & emph. H.W.] and "I have no excuse for this" [! Jerusalem & Athens p.203]. This dependence on others means that as *their* exegesis totters over common grace etc., so his profound edifice of thought totters in sympathy. Van Til is also internally self contradictory and enigmatic, so difficult to understand that even his best student and authority on his work today, Prof. John Frame frankly admits this, "like any human thinker, he is fallible" and notes that Van Til said : "all teaching of Scripture is appar-

ently contradictory".[!!!] An evident failure here to discriminate between paradox and contradiction landed Van Til squarely in the same neo-Hegelian quagmire as Barth, *and Brunner*, this latter who could *also*, like Van Til, *rampantly oppose Barth* from within this *same* epistemological milieu but for different reasons! By contrast, Gordon Clark was an able exegete and commentator, and an excellent teacher able like all good teachers to express profundities in simple terms. With deepest respects, we do not regard him as a "rationalist", rather we regard Van Til as an "irrationalist", or a "contradictionalist"! But we do not hold out Clark, or any other man, including Calvin, as being an infallible "paradigm", **only the Lord Christ** can fulfill that role. (Cf. Matt. 23 vv. 8 - 10).

Book Review

SAVED BY GRACE

A Study of the 5 Points of Calvinism

by

Ronald Cammenga & Ronald Hanko

Reformed Free Publishing Association 1995

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With student's Workbook.

Not since the appearance of Lorraine Boettner's evergreen tome, "The Reformed Doctrine of Predestination" has there, I believe, appeared another unfolding of the Doctrines of Grace, so marked with crystal clear clarity, combined with a satisfying profundity and faithfulness to Scripture until this present volume, subject of this review.

At 257 + X pages this book is somewhat shorter than Boettner's, but if anything, that actually enhances it for the role it was evidently designed to fulfil, namely, the education of young people [and the not-so-young!] into the cardinal dogmas of the Reformed Faith as expressed in the deliberations of Dordrecht and Westminster.

"Active learning" has been a 'buzz' concept in education for some time now. An old Chinese proverb ran something like this : "I hear, and I forget. I see, and I understand. I do, and I remember." With this in mind, one can understand how the authors, both of them ministers of the Protestant Reformed Churches of the USA, put together this instructive and edifying work, and included with it a Student's Workbook. This astute practical touch enhances the work even more, and if the book is a delight to read, then the workbook facilitates the impression of the doctrines on the mind of the student. This active mental activity is of course, essential to true learning. One rarely learns *and remembers* much from books by simply reading them. The mental activity required to fill in the workbook fulfills nicely the dictums embodied in the old Chinese proverb. This, of course, was a concept well known to the ancient theologians of the Church and to the Reformers, whose method in all these things was to formulate catechisms.....these again being devices which force the student into recall situations, thus impressing the lessons deeply on the memory. One should ponder this principle carefully in this hedonistic age in which we live, when we tend to read books just for enjoyment, and subsequently forget 90% and more of what we read in them. Unless we can remember what is taught in these tomes, how can we live by it ? This present volume certainly addresses that problem.

Beginning with an excellently written chapter on the “Sovereignty of God”, the authors follow through with a chapter on each of the five points of Calvinism, followed by a list of further books recommended for reading, then two appendices, the first being extensive citations from the Creeds [Heidelberg Catechism; Belgic Confession; the Canons of Dordt, and the Westminster Standards], arranged in six sections each correlative to one of the chapters in the book. The final appendix is an index of some **362** Scripture passages utilized in a total of **477** citations within the book, that works out at nearly three Scripture citations, many of which are printed in full, to each page of the six teaching chapters to which the Scripture index refers. Veritably, the work is permeated with the Word of God, and carries a value not only as a text-book for learning, but also as a reference source. Not only its text, but also its appendix of Confessional Quotations is of excellent utility, specially for those who do not have access to copies of these important doctrinal creeds.

Both Text and Work books are excellently presented in attractive covers, with a print size of easily readable and pleasing proportions, approximately thus :

The doctrine of perseverance is a most valuable treasure.....

In content, the aim of the authors has been to expound God’s Sovereignty in Salvation along the lines of the mnemonic TULIP, and under each heading the typical chapter evolves logically viz.

- A. The Doctrine.**
- B. Scripture Passages** relevant, with comments.
- C. Difficult Passages**, with explanatory comments.
- D. Objections**, duly adumbrated and judiciously criticised and refuted.
- E. Denials of the Doctrine** under consideration analysed, criticised and refuted.
- F. Practical Importance** of the Doctrine, how it bears on the Christian life.
- G. Relations** to the Other Four Points.

Each section **A, B**, etc., may be broken down into further sub-sections. For instance, the section on Total Depravity considers the differences between the false doctrine that total depravity does not mean total corruption, and the true Scriptural position that maintains the contrary. Likewise, the notions of ‘common grace’ and ‘free-offerism’ are considered under this heading, noting how both these modern deviations from orthodox Calvinism carry implications that undermine the doctrine of Total Depravity. Pelagianism, Semi-Pelagianism, and Arminianism, are adumbrated under the sub-heading “Denials of Total Depravity”, and, like ‘common grace’ and the ‘free offer’, they crop up for consideration again under the headings of other chapters as appropriate.

Permeating all this are the abundant Scripture references, many printed in full, which come in like an avalanche to sweep away any doubts or objections and to

Book Review: Saved by Grace

establish the truth in all its veracity as the Word of God.

The clear logical tidiness of the book befits the Scriptural apostolic command to “do all things decently and in order” [1 Cor. 14 : 40], and is of course, of vital importance in the matter of instruction. Untidy lesson structure can be a characteristic all too prevalent amongst teachers and contributes to confusion amongst the students, but such strictures are certainly not applicable to this book. It is not necessary to be prolix like the Puritans, in order to be profound and plenary in one’s teaching method, on the contrary, profundity is better conveyed in simple, logical, “bytes”, as it were, which the student can take in “byte” at a time, and gain a proper understanding of what he or she is taking in. Logical structure is also more easily retained in the memory, and more easily mentally traced for recall as and when required.

Many today in theological circles are wary of ‘logicality’, and do not like to see things set out clearly as epitomized by Cammenga and Hanko’s work in this volume. Against such objectors it must be asserted herewith that the prime purpose of a text-book is not to display the author’s profound learning in a heady plethora of dazzling literary pyro-technics that bamboozle the reader. No, the primary purpose of a text-book is to teach, to make the material assimilable by the students who are expected to read it, and above all, to glorify God in so doing as it leads those students into a deeper appreciation of His Being, Wisdom, Power, Holiness, Justice, Goodness and Truth, and through all that to worship Him in Spirit and in Truth. By that high standard this volume and its workbook must be given high marks indeed.

We unhesitatingly commend it for its faithful Scriptural and Confessional orthodoxy and its utility as a teaching source, and would exhort all Christians, young and old, who are needing to grasp the Reformed Faith in all its pristine Scriptural purity, to purchase these two volumes, and to work through them diligently. And we might say, too, that the experienced and well-read ‘theological Christian’ would benefit from them.....they provide a veritable “refresher course” in those vital things that we should all keep well primed in our minds.

Readers may obtain these volumes from the Covenant Reformed Bookstore in Northern Ireland. To do so they should enquire with the Book Secretary, Mr. Sean Courtney, whom they can contact on : 01266 41200 [Overseas readers should prefix the appropriate United Kingdom code for dialling from their country].

Take heed unto thyself, and unto the DOCTRINE; continue in them: for in so doing this thou shalt both save thyself and them that hear thee.

1 Timothy 4 : 16